



9 Theme: human ingenuity

Themes · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Human ingenuity covers sub-topics such as inventions, technology, art, media, and innovation in science. Receptive and productive tasks on this theme often involve reading or writing about a specific innovation's purpose, impact and any risks or ethical considerations, so strong responses go beyond describing what something is to evaluate why it matters.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Model detail-focused reading question and answer for a short article about a solar-powered water purifier: Q: 'What problem does the invention solve?' A: 'It provides clean drinking water in areas without reliable electricity, using only sunlight.'

Quick check · multiple choice

Which sub-topic belongs under the theme of human ingenuity?

- A Family relationships
- B Scientific innovation and technology
- C Personal daily routines
- D Types of holidays

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Read the short text below, then answer the three questions in complete sentences. [20]

TEXT: A team of university students has developed a low-cost app that translates sign language gestures into text in real time, using only a smartphone camera. The app is currently being tested in three schools for deaf students and has already reduced communication delays reported by teachers.

1. What problem does this invention address? (gist)
2. What technology does the app rely on? (detail)
3. Where is the app currently being tested? (detail)

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

A strong answer:

- Q1: identifies the overall purpose, e.g. 'it helps translate sign language into text so deaf students can communicate more easily'
- Q2: states 'a smartphone camera' precisely
- Q3: states 'three schools for deaf students', taken directly and accurately from the text
- All answers are in complete sentences, precise, and avoid unnecessary copying of full sentences from the source

Quick check answer

B. Scientific innovation and technology are core sub-topics of human ingenuity, alongside art, media and invention.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English B guide (2018).

Original FagusED teaching material. Not an official IB publication; the sample scenarios and language are invented and generic.